

Endangered Birds

Grades: Middle

Objectives: As a result of completing this activity, students will:

- (Art) Create placard costumes and conduct dramatic role-plays to determine the reasons for the endangerment of selected migratory birds.
- (Science) Develop an understanding of the ecological reasons for certain species' endangerment and possible extinction.

Materials:

- field guides
- pieces of large poster board or poster paper
- magic markers
- cord or yarn
- hole reinforcers (found in office supply stores)
- pictures of extinct birds such as the GREAT AUK, PASSENGER PIGEON, CAROLINA PARAKEET, HEATH HEN, and LABRADOR DUCK (optional)
- list of threatened and endangered birds (See Appendix)

Instructions:

Activity I : Dateline Endangered

- 1) Discuss concepts of extinction and endangerment referring to bird species that have become extinct such as the GREAT AUK, PASSENGER PIGEON, CAROLINA PARAKEET, HEATH HEN, and LABRADOR DUCK. (refer also to the discussion on endangerment in Meet the Migrants).
- 2) Distribute the list of Endangered Migratory Birds (see Appendix). Tell students they will be creating life-size poster-placards of an endangered bird of their choice. Have students identify in field guides several of the birds listed as endangered in field guides. Have each student choose an endangered bird and research its basic habitat requirements. Students can get most of the necessary habitat information in their field guides.
- 3) Distribute poster paper, markers, crayons, and other drawing materials and have the students create an enlarged image of their bird to fit the size of the paper. Once students have completed their endangered bird

posters, punch holes in the top of the posters and thread the top with a piece of cord or yarn. Reinforce the holes with circular, adhesive reinforcers to avoid tearing.

4) Divide the class into two groups. Tell members of group one that they will be interviewing members of group two. Members of group two will "wear" their endangered bird posters. The job of group one is to determine why the members of group two have become endangered. Have the students in group one develop a series of interview questions following a line of inquiry, to develop critical-thinking skills. Questions may include but are not limited to the following:

- a) What bird species are you?
- b) What is your habitat like?
- c) What are your favorite foods?
- d) Where do you spend the winter?
- e) Where do you spend the summer?
- f) What is happening to your habitat in your breeding grounds?
- g) What is happening to your habitat in your wintering grounds?

5) Once members of group one have developed their questions, have them pair up with one of the members of group two and conduct their investigative interviews. Once the interviews are complete, have each member of group one present the results of his or her interview. Presentations by members of group one should adequately address the causes of why the species represented by his partner (from group two) has become threatened or endangered?

6) Now switch and have members of group two interview members of group one.

Activity II: Endangered Species Skits

1) Cluster the students into groups of four or five. Tell the students they will be creating skits based on the information they obtained about why the birds represented on their placards became endangered, what conservation efforts could be conducted to help them, and what may happen if nothing is done. Have them bring their placards with them to the working groups.

2) Have the students in each group present their skits to the rest of the class. The endangered species skits could provide a wonderful presentation for a school-wide International Migratory Bird Day festival.

Evaluation:

Do students' placard posters effectively illustrate the endangered species they chose? Do the presentations of the results of students' interviews and the group skits reflect an understanding of the concepts of endangerment and extinction and the main reasons why these occur?